Tawang was a defender's nightmare. Situated on a sloping plateau with the monastery dominating the landscape, it could be assaulted from multiple directions. The most obvious and logical approach was across Bum-la, the pass that straddled the watershed directly to the north. This route would place the Chinese in a very strong position, for their administrative bases supported by roads were just across the McMahon Line. The second line of approach available to the Chinese was the Tawang-Mukdang-la-Geyshe-la axis that would allow them to attack from the east. The third approach was down the Khenzemane-Zimithang-Shakti-Lumla track that allowed them to approach Tawang from the west.

Brigadier Kalyan Singh was an inspiring figure and exuded calm confidence. His absence from Tawang between 19 and 22 October was sorely felt, especially since the Chinese build-up opposite Bum-la was obvious. Since 21 October, commander 62 Brigade, Brigadier Nandi Lal, along with his entire Tactical HQ, had been camping at Tawang. The formation had started from Ranchi with three infantry battalions, but had reached Tezpur with only 4 Garhwal Rifles as the other two units had been diverted to Jorhat. The Garhwalis had subsequently been transferred to 4 Artillery Brigade, leaving 62 Brigade with no troops. Considering that Bum-la was expected to be a classic infantry battle supported by artillery, it would have made sense to not only send the Garhwalis but also place 1 Sikh under Brigadier Lal. This was done on 24 October, but by then the situation had changed most dramatically.

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Towards the end of October Bum-la is extremely picturesque, its barren rocky slopes covered with rust-coloured vegetation. The approach from Tawang is along zigzagging tracks that climb sharply up, past a sprinkling of small lakes. The vegetation soon falls away and the pass itself is more of an opening into the flat plateau of Tibet. One platoon under the command of Jemadar A. K. Roy of 5 Assam Rifles was located at Bum-la itself, while various sub-units of 1 Sikh were located on the important features behind them.

The Twin Peaks Hill, two kilometres south of the pass, dominates the entire area and affords a commanding view of the McMahon Line. This rocky escarpment, known as the IB Ridge, made it a tactically perfect